

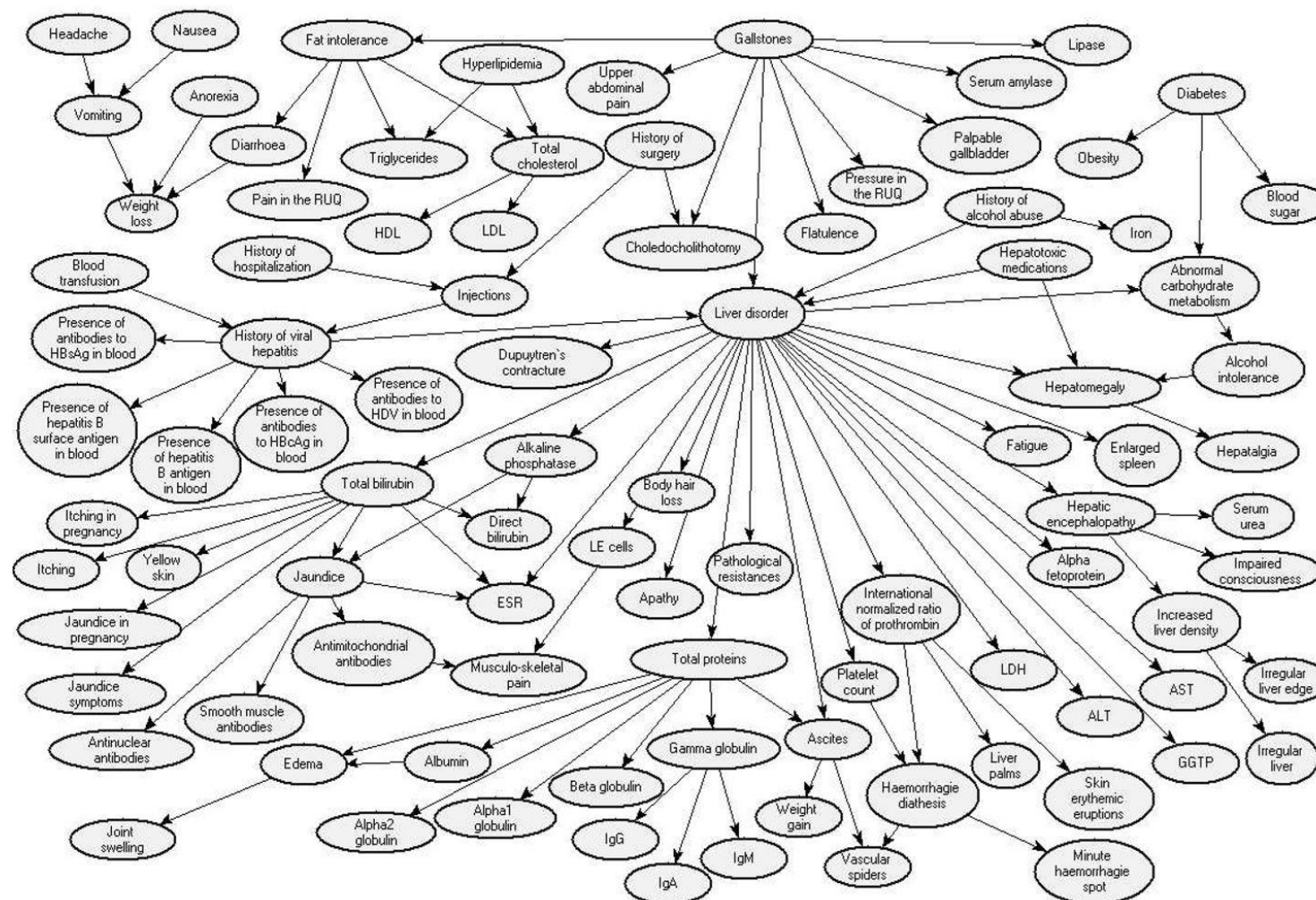
**CSE 471**  
**Introduction to Artificial Intelligence**

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Spring 2025

# Probabilistic graphical models (PGMs)

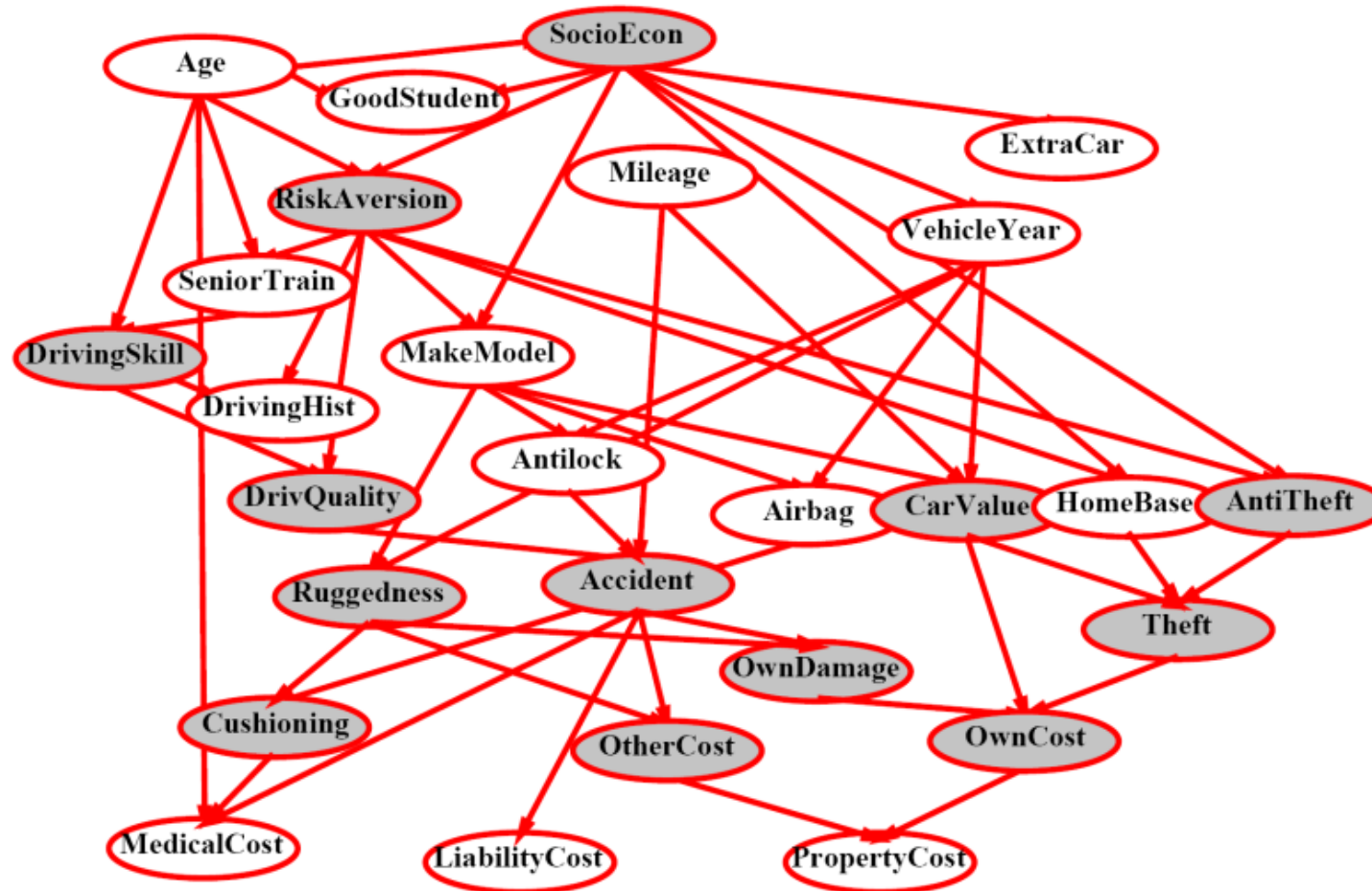
- Two problems with using full joint distribution tables as our probabilistic models:
  - Other than very simple cases, the joint distribution table is too big to represent explicitly
  - Hard to learn (estimate) anything empirically about more than a few variables at a time
- PGMs use a graphical structure to *more concisely represent distributions*
- **Bayesian networks**: directed PGM exploiting (conditional) independence
  - Describe complex joint distributions using simple, local distributions (conditional probabilities)
  - Local interactions chain together to give global, indirect interactions

# BN application: medical diagnosis



A Bayesian Network Model for Diagnosis of Liver Disorders – Agnieszka Onisko, M.S., Marek J. Druzdzel, Ph.D., and Hanna Wasyluk, M.D., Ph.D.- September 1999.

# BN application: insurance



# Bayesian network structure

- Nodes: variables (with domains)
  - Can be observed or unobserved
- Arcs: interactions between variables
  - Indicate “direct influence” between variables
  - Formally: encode conditional independence (more later)
- Intuition: it helps to think of arrows as direct causation (though in general, they don't)

# Coin flips

- N independent coin flips

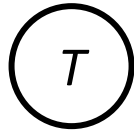
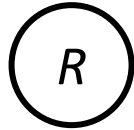


- No interaction between variables: *absolute independence*

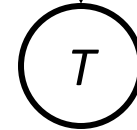
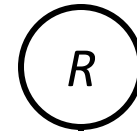
# Traffic

- Variables:  $R$ : it rains  
 $T$ : there is traffic

- Model 1: independence



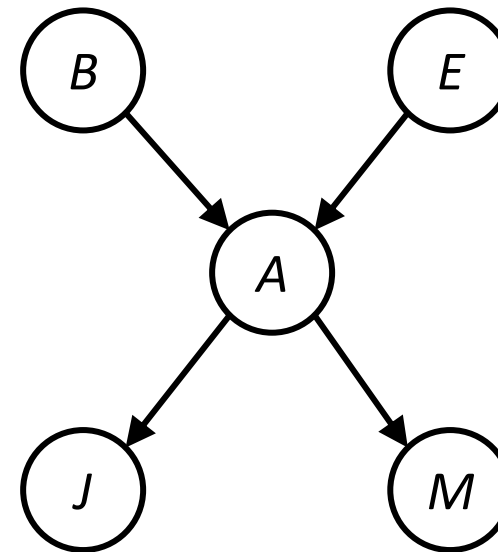
- Model 2: rain causes traffic



- Why is an agent using model 2 better?

# Alarm network

- Variables: B: Burglary  
A: Alarm goes off  
M: Mary calls  
J: John calls  
E: Earthquake

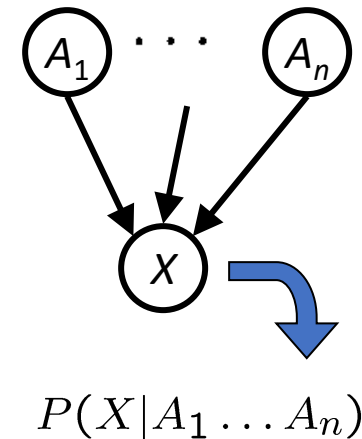


- A burglar or an earthquake may set the alarm off
- The alarm can cause neighbor John or Mary to call



# Bayesian network semantics

- A set of nodes, one per variable
- A directed acyclic graph
- A conditional distribution for each node
  - $P(X \mid \text{parents}(X))$
  - CPT: conditional probability table
  - Description of a noisy “causal” process
- *BN = graph (topology) + local conditional probabilities*



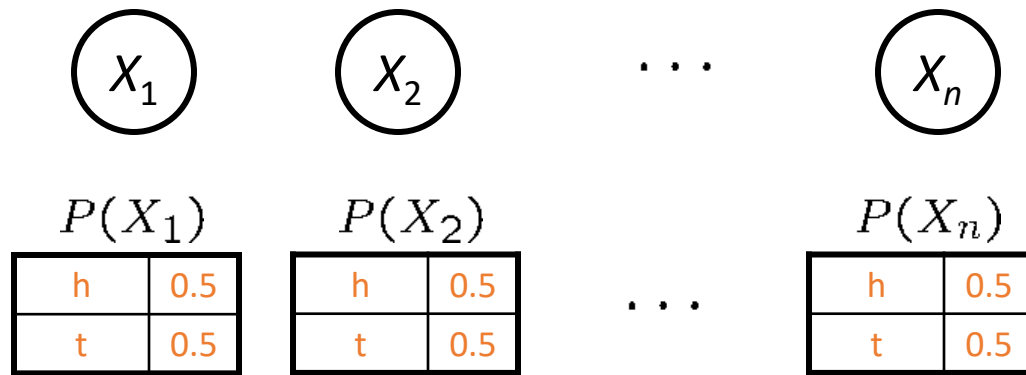
# Probabilities in BNs

- Bayesian networks *implicitly* encode joint distributions As a product of local conditional distributions

$$P(x_1, \dots, x_n) = \prod_{i=1}^n P(x_i | \text{parents}(X_i))$$

- Check: Are we guaranteed that this results in a valid joint distribution?
- Chain rule** (valid for all distributions): Repeated application of product rule
  - $P(x_1, x_2, \dots, x_n) = P(x_n | x_1, \dots, x_{n-1}) P(x_1, \dots, x_{n-1}) = P(x_n | x_1, \dots, x_{n-1}) P(x_{n-1} | x_1, \dots, x_{n-2}) P(x_1, \dots, x_{n-2})$   
 $= \dots = \prod_{i=1}^n P(x_i | x_1, \dots, x_{i-1})$
- Note: this implies conditional independences:  $P(x_i | x_1, \dots, x_{i-1}) = P(x_i | \text{parents}(X_i))$  (more on this later)

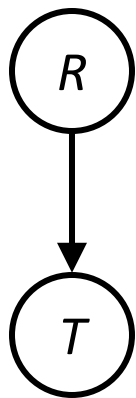
# Coin flips



$$P(h, h, t, h) = P(X_1 = h)P(X_2 = h)P(X_3 = t)P(X_4 = h) = \left(\frac{1}{2}\right)\left(\frac{1}{2}\right)\left(\frac{1}{2}\right)\left(\frac{1}{2}\right) = \frac{1}{16}$$

*Only distributions whose variables are absolutely independent can be represented by a BN with no arcs.*

# Traffic



$P(R)$

|      |       |
|------|-------|
| $+r$ | $1/4$ |
| $-r$ | $3/4$ |

$P(T|R)$

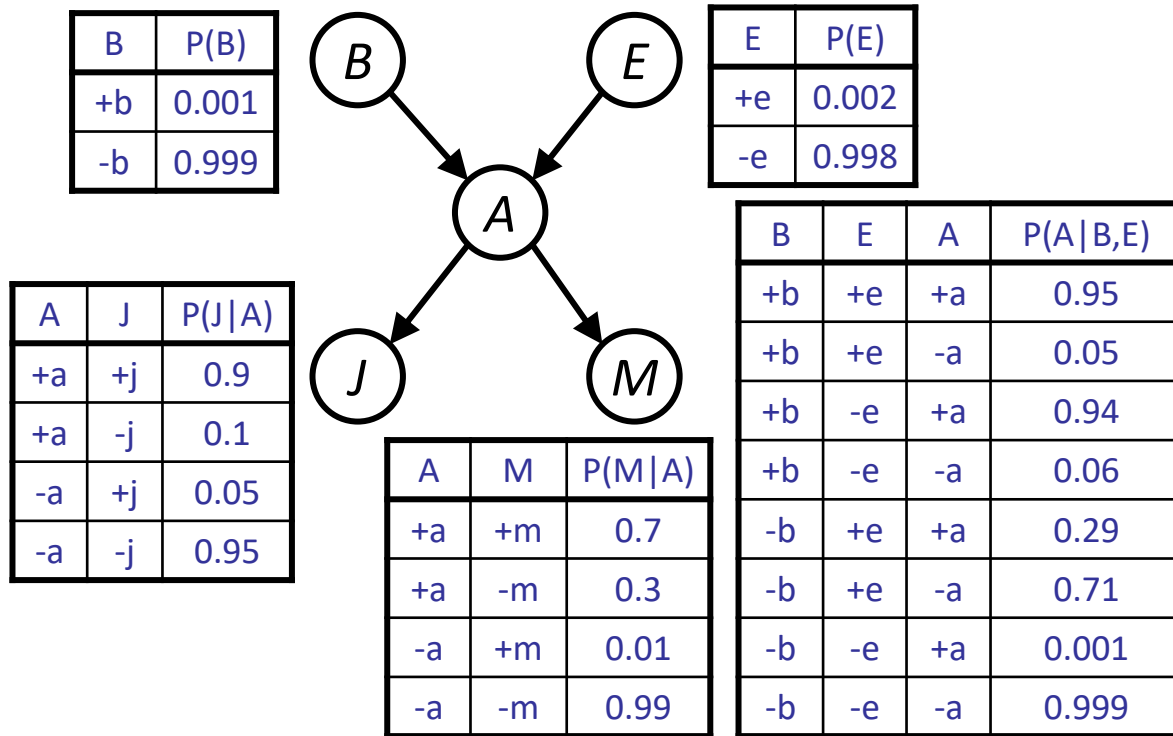
|      |      |       |
|------|------|-------|
| $+r$ | $+t$ | $3/4$ |
|      | $-t$ | $1/4$ |
| $-r$ | $+t$ | $1/2$ |
|      | $-t$ | $1/2$ |

$$P(+r, -t) = P(-t|+r)P(+r) = \left(\frac{1}{4}\right)\left(\frac{1}{4}\right) = \frac{1}{16}$$

$P(T, R)$

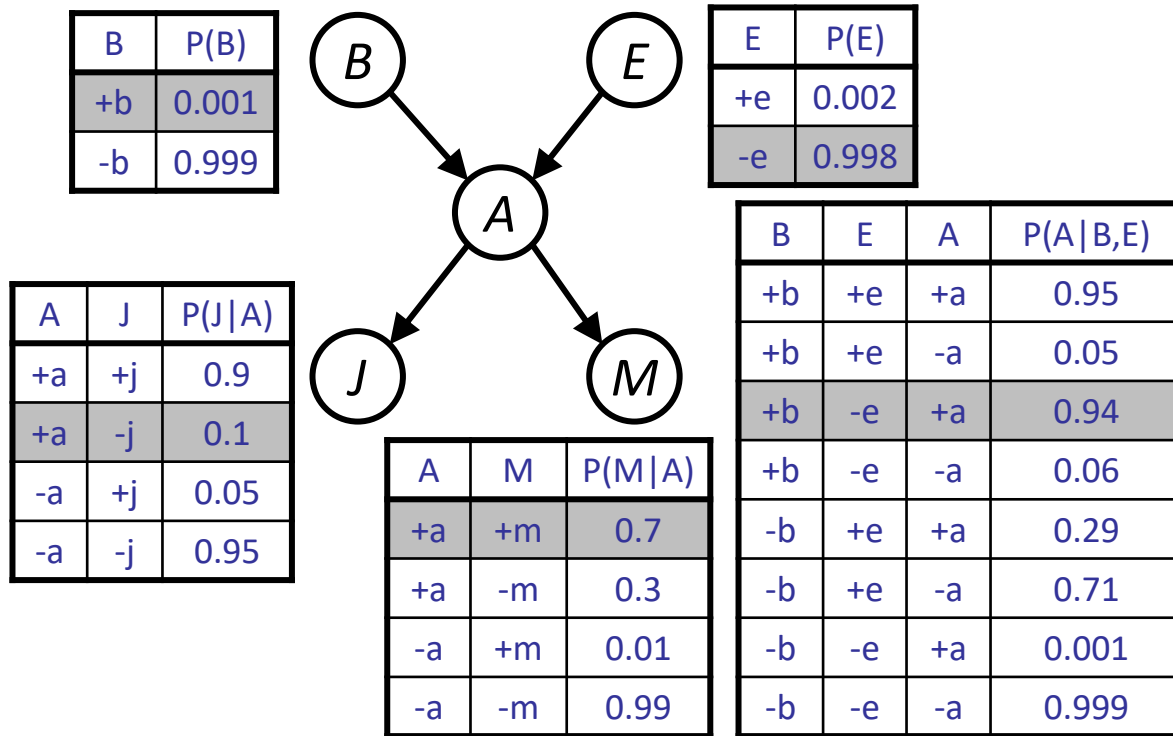
|      |      |        |
|------|------|--------|
| $+r$ | $+t$ | $3/16$ |
| $+r$ | $-t$ | $1/16$ |
| $-r$ | $+t$ | $6/16$ |
| $-r$ | $-t$ | $6/16$ |

# Alarm



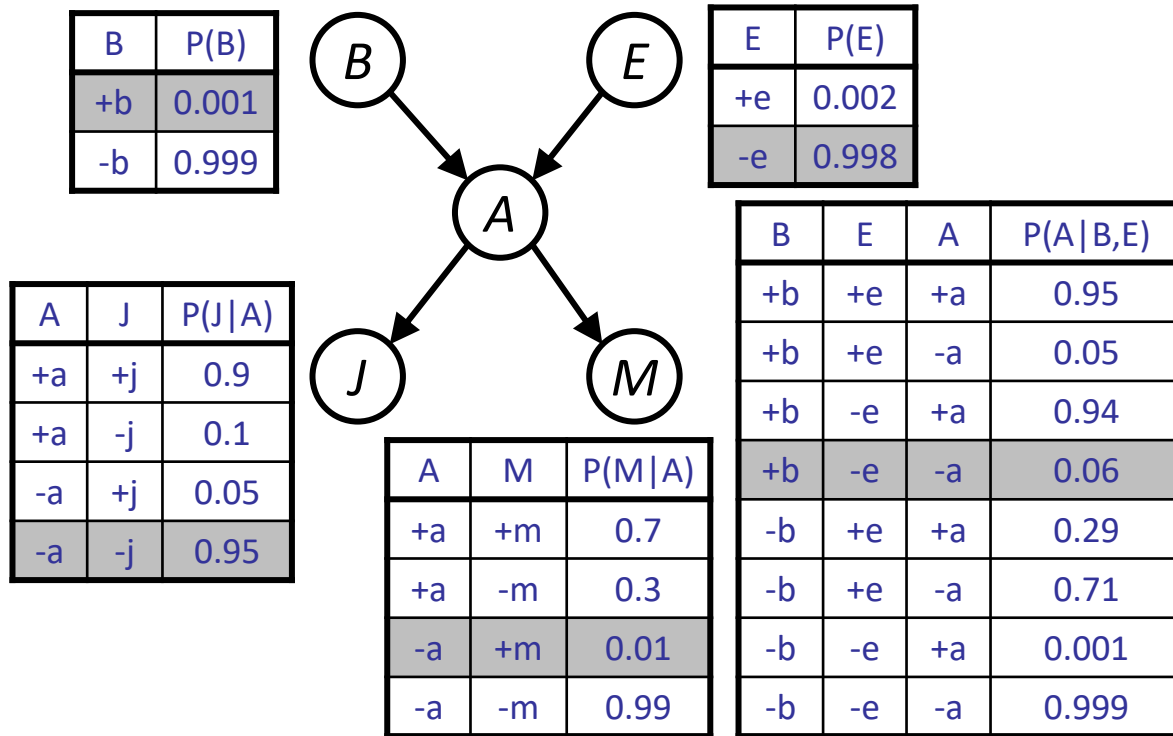
$$P(+b, -e, +a, -j, +m) = P(+b)P(-e)P(+a|+b, -e)P(-j|+a)P(+m|+a)$$

# Alarm



$$\begin{aligned}
 &P(+b, -e, +a, -j, +m) \\
 &= P(+b)P(-e)P(+a|+b, -e)P(-j|+a)P(+m|+a) \\
 &= 0.001 \times 0.998 \times 0.94 \times 0.1 \times 0.7
 \end{aligned}$$

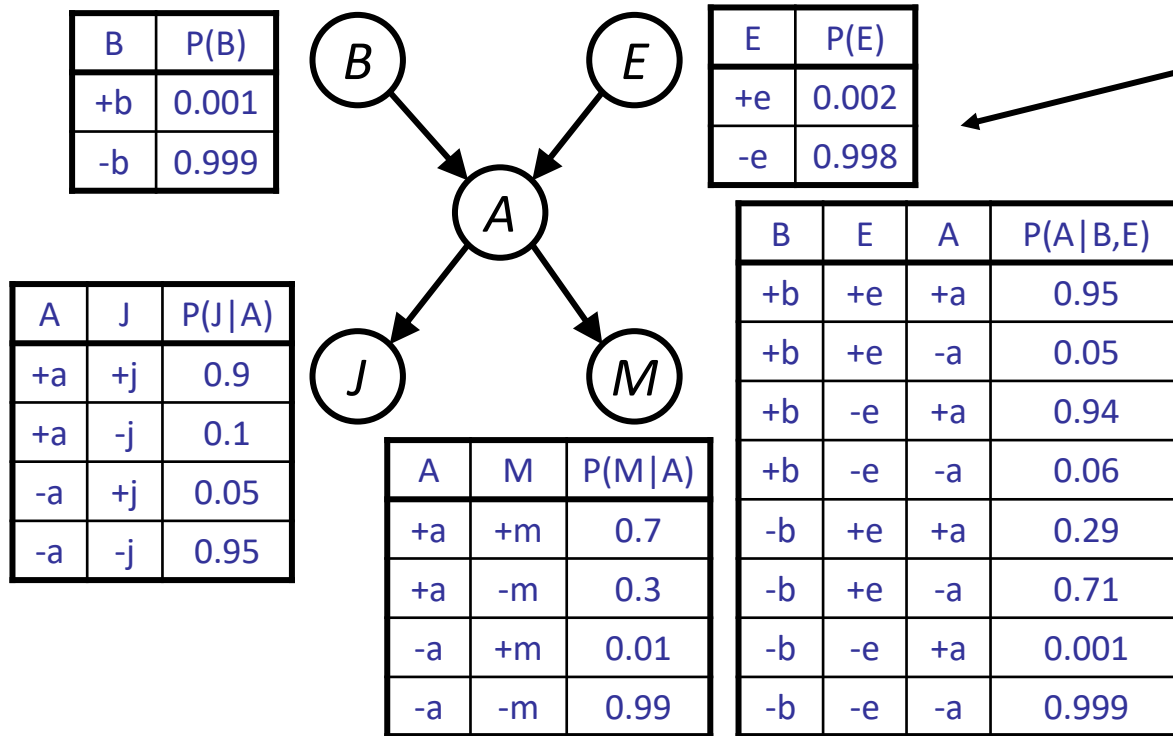
# Alarm



$$\begin{aligned}
 &P(+b, -e, +a, -j, +m) \\
 &= P(+b)P(-e)P(+a|+b, -e)P(-j|+a)P(+m|+a) \\
 &= 0.001 \times 0.998 \times 0.94 \times 0.1 \times 0.7
 \end{aligned}$$

$$\begin{aligned}
 &P(+b, -e, -a, -j, +m) \\
 &= P(+b)P(-e)P(-a|+b, -e)P(-j|-a)P(+m|-a) \\
 &= 0.001 \times 0.998 \times 0.06 \times 0.95 \times 0.01
 \end{aligned}$$

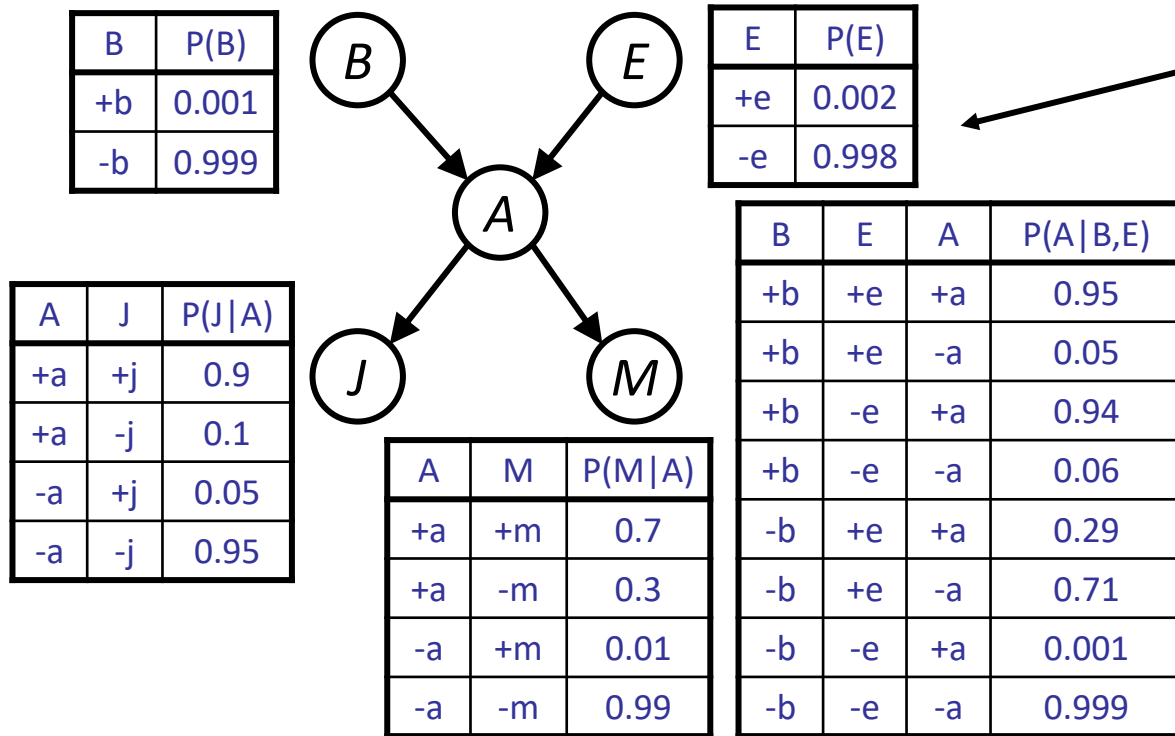
# Size of BN



How many independent probability values (free parameters) needed for this table?

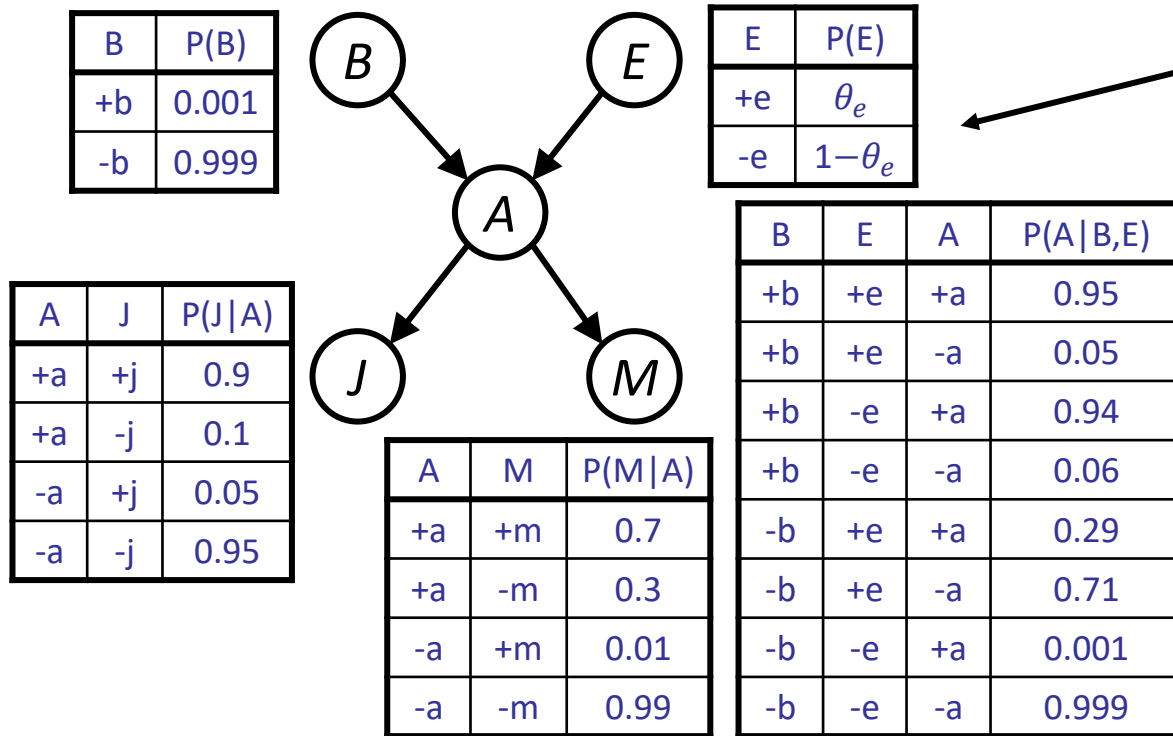


# Size of BN



How many independent probability values (free parameters) needed for this table?

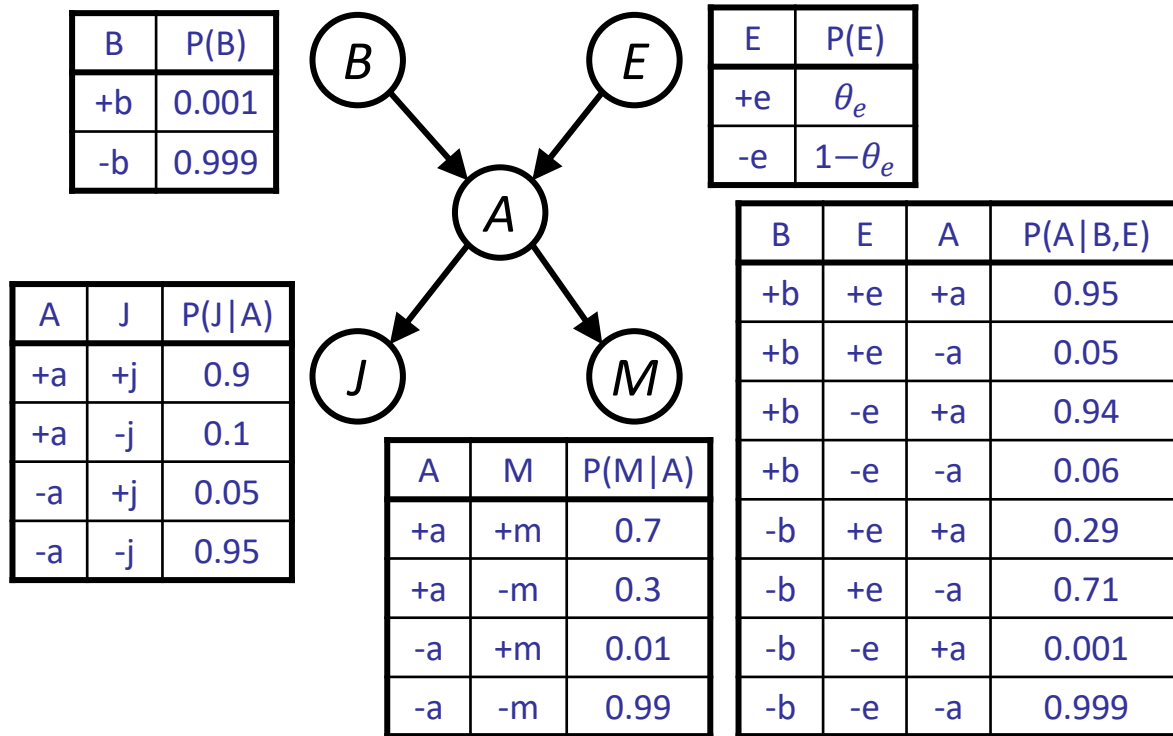
# Size of BN



How many independent probability values (free parameters) needed for this table?

*Only 1! The table must sum up to 1.*

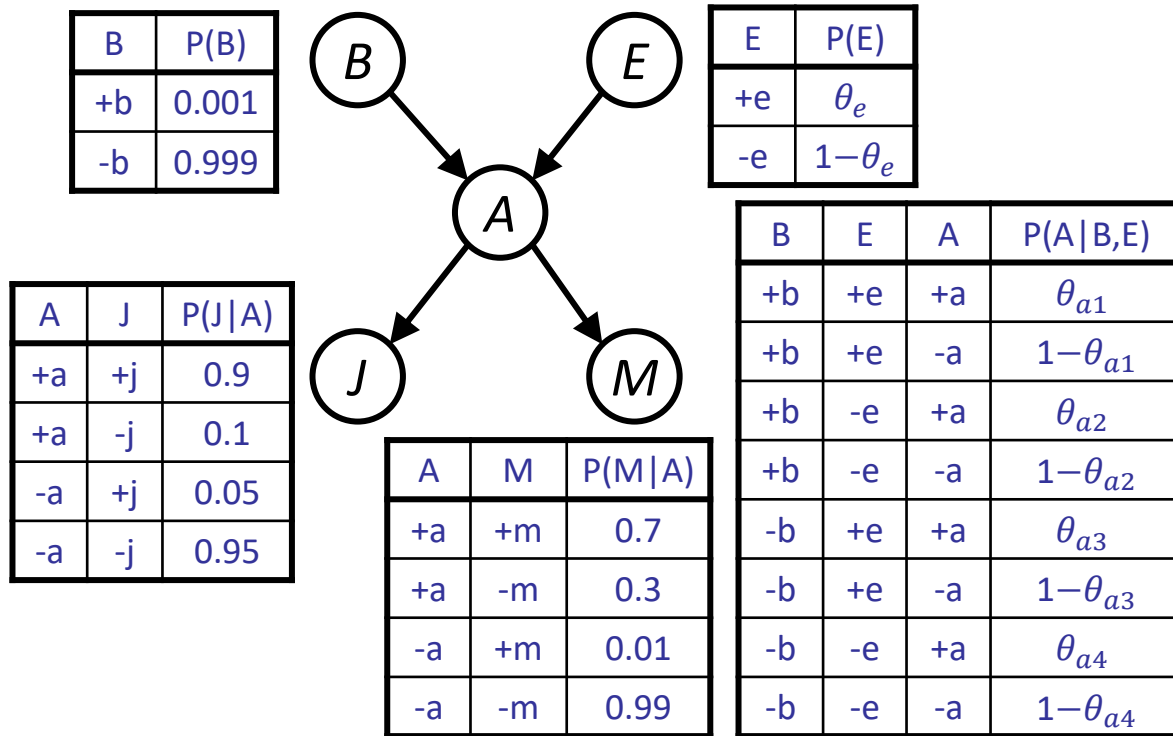
# Size of BN



How many independent probability values (free parameters) in this table?



# Size of BN

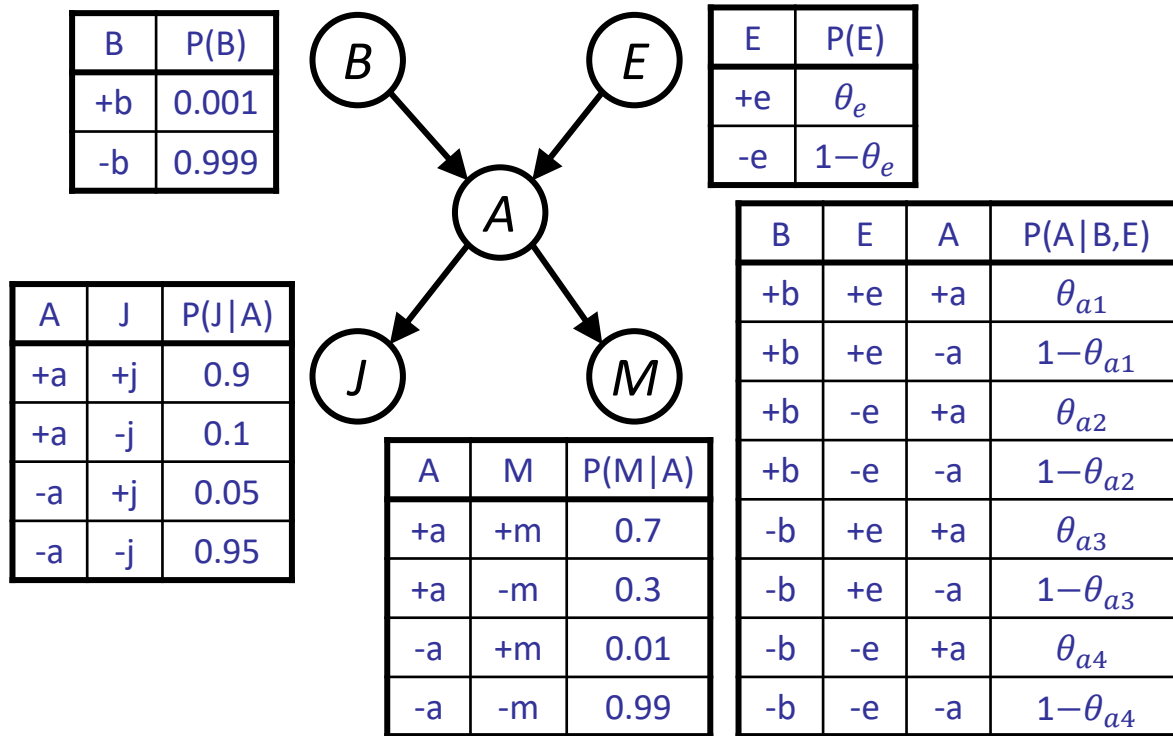


How many independent probability values (free parameters) in this table?

*4 free parameters.*

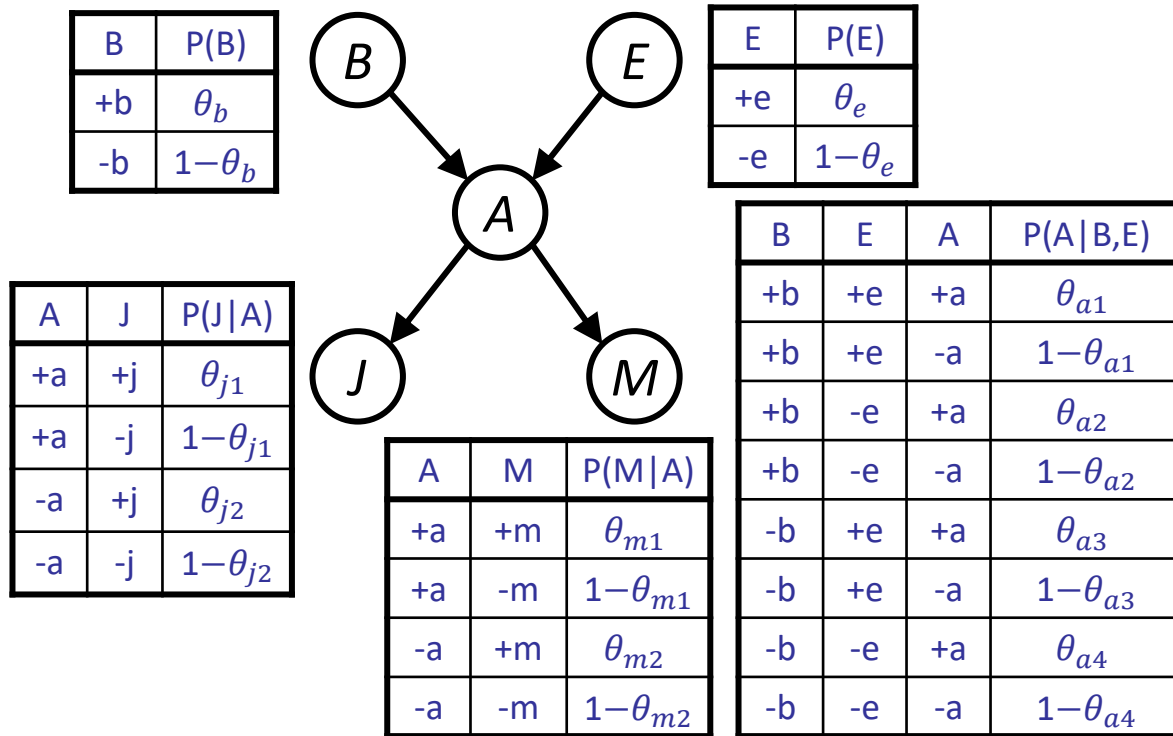
*For each assignment to the parents, the conditional distribution must sum to 1.*

# Size of BN



How many independent probability values (free parameters) *for this Bayesian network*?

# Size of BN



How many independent probability values (free parameters) *for this Bayesian network*?

$$1 + 1 + 2 + 2 + 4 = 10$$

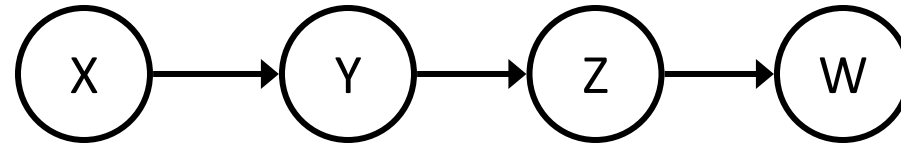
*As opposed to  $2^5 - 1 = 31$  independent parameters for the full joint distribution table*

# Size of BN

- How big is a joint distribution table over  $N$  Boolean variables?  $O(2^N)$   
over  $N$  variables with  $d$  values?  $O(d^N)$
- How big is a Bayesian network CPT for a Boolean variable that has  $k$  parents?  $O(2^k)$   
a variable with  $d$  values and  $k$  parents?  $O(d^k(d-1)) = O(d^{k+1})$
- How big is a Bayesian network with  $N$  Boolean variables that have at most  $k$  parents?  $O(N \cdot 2^k)$   
with  $N$  variables with  $d$  values and at most  $k$  parents?  $O(N \cdot d^{k+1})$
- Huge space savings from BNs compared to joint distribution tables!
- Also easier to elicit local CPTs and faster to answer queries

*BNs achieve compact representation by making (conditional) independence assumptions!*

# Example: Independence in BN

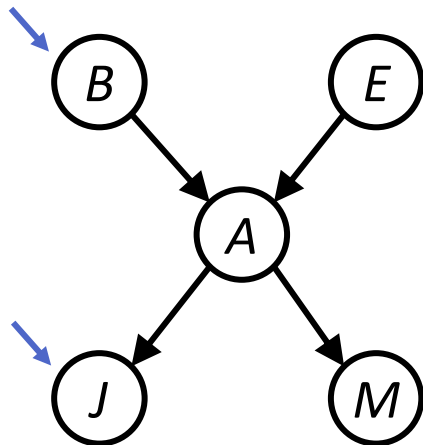


- Conditional independence assumptions directly from simplifications in chain rule:
  - Chain rule (always true):  $P(X, Y, Z, W) = P(X)P(Y|X)P(Z|X, Y)P(W|X, Y, Z)$
  - BN structure implies:  $P(X, Y, Z, W) = P(X)P(Y|X)P(Z|Y)P(W|Z)$
- $P(Z|X, Y) = P(Z|Y)$        $Z \perp X | Y$
- $P(W|X, Y, Z) = P(W|Z)$        $W \perp X, Y | Z$



# Independence in BN structure

- $\text{Parents}(V) = \{N: \text{there is an edge } N \rightarrow V\}$
- $\text{Descendants}(V) = \{N: \text{there is a directed path from } V \text{ to } N\}$
- $\text{Non-descendants}(V)$ : variables other than  $V$ ,  $\text{Parents}(V)$ ,  $\text{Descendants}(V)$
- *Markovian assumption*: Every node  $V$  is conditionally independent of  $\text{Non-descendants}(V)$  given  $\text{Parents}(V)$



$\text{Parents}(B) = \{\}$

$\text{Non-descendants}(B) = \{E\}$

Burglary is independent of Earthquake:  $B \perp E$

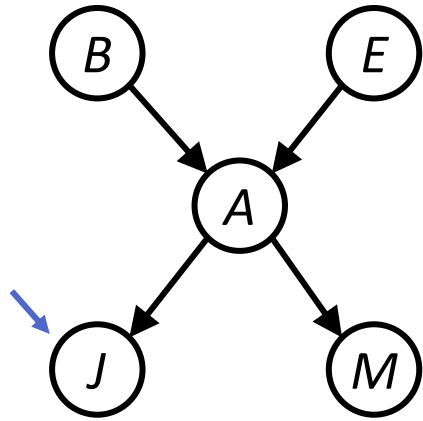
$\text{Parents}(J) = \{A\}$

$\text{Non-descendants}(J) = \{B, E, M\}$

$J \perp B, E, M \mid A$

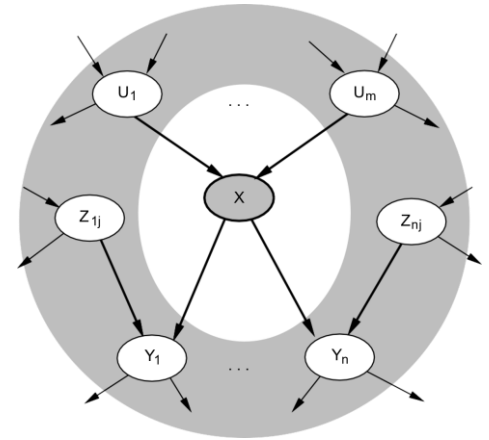
# Independence in BN structure

- **Markov blanket:** parents, children, and children's parents
- Each node is conditionally independent of all other nodes given its Markov blanket



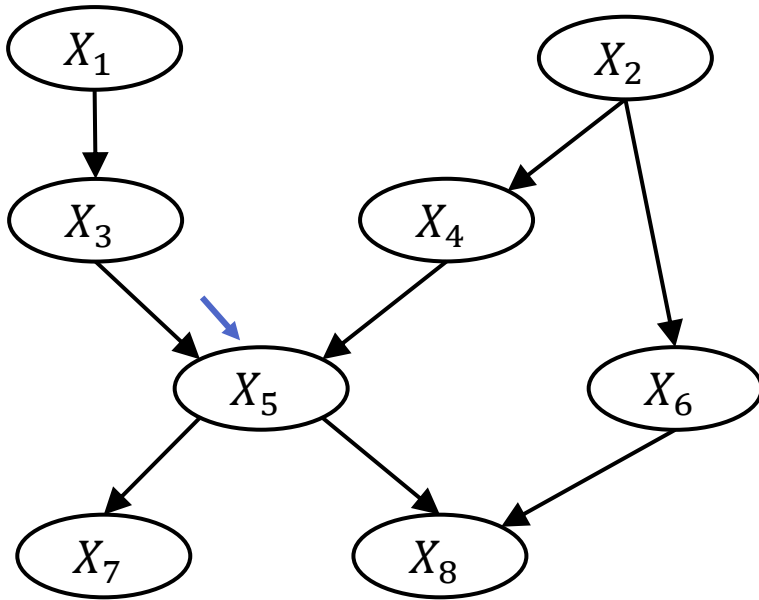
Markov-blanket(J)={A}

$$J \perp B, E, M \mid A$$



# Independence in BN structure

- **Markov blanket:** parents, children, and children's parents
- Each node is conditionally independent of all other nodes given its Markov blanket



$$\text{Markov-blanket}(X_5) = \{X_3, X_4, X_6, X_7, X_8\}$$

$$X_5 \perp X_1, X_2 \mid X_3, X_4, X_6, X_7, X_8$$

$$\text{Parents}(X_5) = \{X_3, X_4\}$$

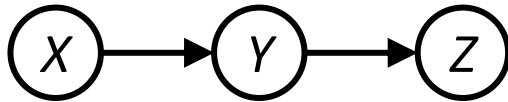
$$\text{Non-descendants}(X_5) = \{X_1, X_2, X_6\}$$

$$X_5 \perp X_1, X_2, X_6 \mid X_3, X_4$$

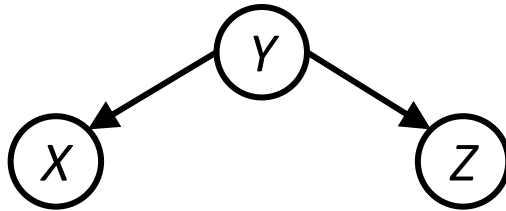
*How do we in general prove or disprove whether two nodes are independent given certain evidence?*

# D-separation

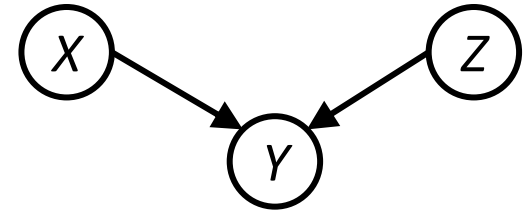
- We can study the (conditional) independence properties assumed by a BN graph structure
- Complex cases can be analyzed using three configurations over triples of nodes:



*"Causal chains"*

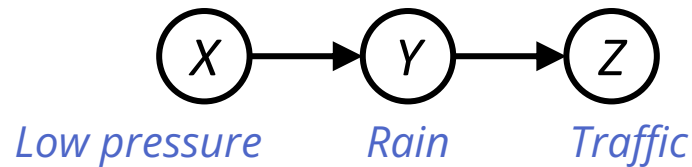


*"Common cause"*



*"Common effect"*

# Causal chains

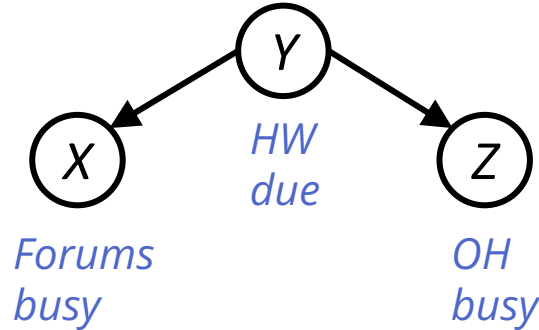


- Is X independent of Z?
  - **No!** Suffices to show one counterexample set of CPTs for which X is not independent of Z
  - E.g., low pressure causes rain causes traffic & high pressure causes no rain causes no traffic
- Is X independent of Z given Y? **Yes!**

$$P(z|x, y) = \frac{P(x, y, z)}{P(x, y)} = \frac{P(x)P(y|x)P(z|y)}{P(x)P(y|x)} = P(z|y)$$

*Evidence along the chain “blocks” the influence*

# Common cause

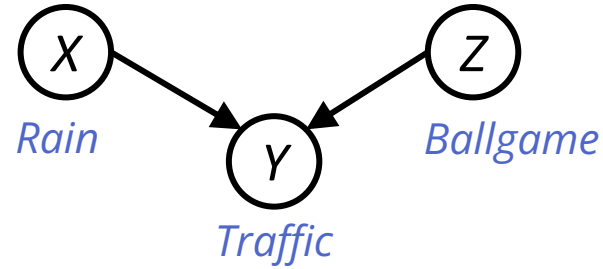


- Is X independent of Z?
  - **No!** Suffices to show one counterexample set of CPTs for which X is not independent of Z
  - E.g., homework due causes both forums and office hours to be busy
- Is X independent of Z given Y? **Yes!**

$$P(z|x, y) = \frac{P(x, y, z)}{P(x, y)} = \frac{P(x|y)P(y)P(z|y)}{P(x|y)P(y)} = P(z|y)$$

*Observing the cause blocks influence between effects*

# Common effect

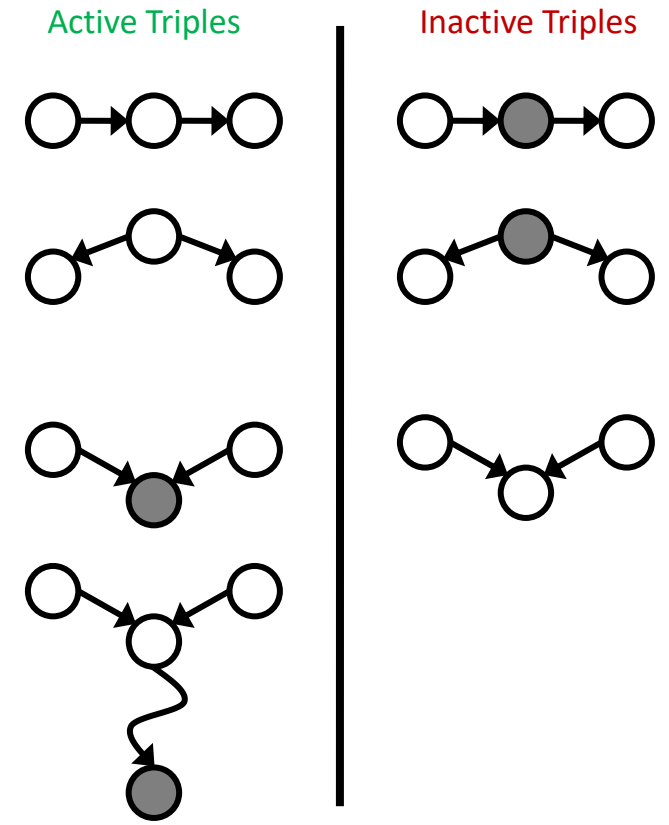


- Is X independent of Z?
  - **Yes!** The ballgame and the rain causes traffic, but they are not correlated
  - *Exercise: prove that they must be independent*
- Is X independent of Z given Y?
  - **No!** Seeing traffic puts the rain and the ballgame in competition as explanation

*Observing an effect **activates** influence between possible causes  
(this is backwards from the other two cases)*

# D-separation (textbook algorithm)

- In a given BN structure, are variables  $X$  and  $Y$  independent given evidence variables  $\{Z\}$ ?
- Recipe: analyze the graph for *active paths*
  1. Shade evidence nodes
  2. Consider all undirected paths from  $X$  to  $Y$
  3. Independence if no active paths (i.e.,  $X$  and  $Y$  are “d-separated” by  $Z$ ).  
A path is active if all triples in it are active.
- A path is active if each triple is active:
  - Causal chain ( $X \rightarrow Y \rightarrow Z$ ) and common cause ( $X \leftarrow Y \rightarrow Z$ ): if  $Y$  is unobserved
  - Common effect ( $X \rightarrow Y \leftarrow Z$ ): if  $Y$  or one of its descendants is observed



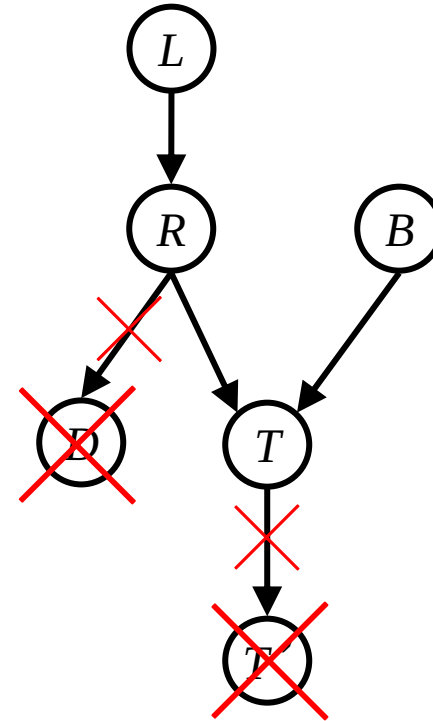


# D-separation: graphical test

- In a given BN structure, are variables  $X$  and  $Y$  independent given evidence variables  $\{Z\}$ ?
- i.e., Are  $X$  and  $Y$  d-separated by  $\{Z\}$ ?
- Graphical test:
  1. Delete any leaf node  $W$  from the DAG as long as  $W$  is not in  $X$ ,  $Y$ , or  $\{Z\}$
  2. Repeat Step 1 until no more nodes can be deleted
  3. Delete all edges outgoing from nodes in  $\{Z\}$
  4.  $X$  and  $Y$  are d-separated (independent) given  $Z$  iff they are ***disconnected*** in the resulting DAG

# Example

1. Delete leaf nodes not in  $X$ ,  $Y$ , or  $\{Z\}$
2. Repeat Step 1 until no more can be deleted
3. Delete all outgoing edges from  $\{Z\}$
4.  $X \perp Y \mid Z$  if  $X$  and  $Y$  are **disconnected** in the resulting DAG

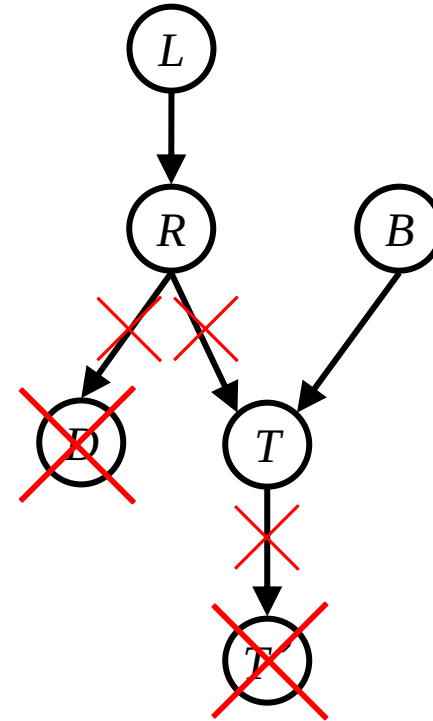


$L \perp B \mid T$  ?

*Not d-separated*

# Example

1. Delete leaf nodes not in  $X$ ,  $Y$ , or  $\{Z\}$
2. Repeat Step 1 until no more can be deleted
3. Delete all outgoing edges from  $\{Z\}$
4.  $X \perp Y \mid Z$  if  $X$  and  $Y$  are **disconnected** in the resulting DAG

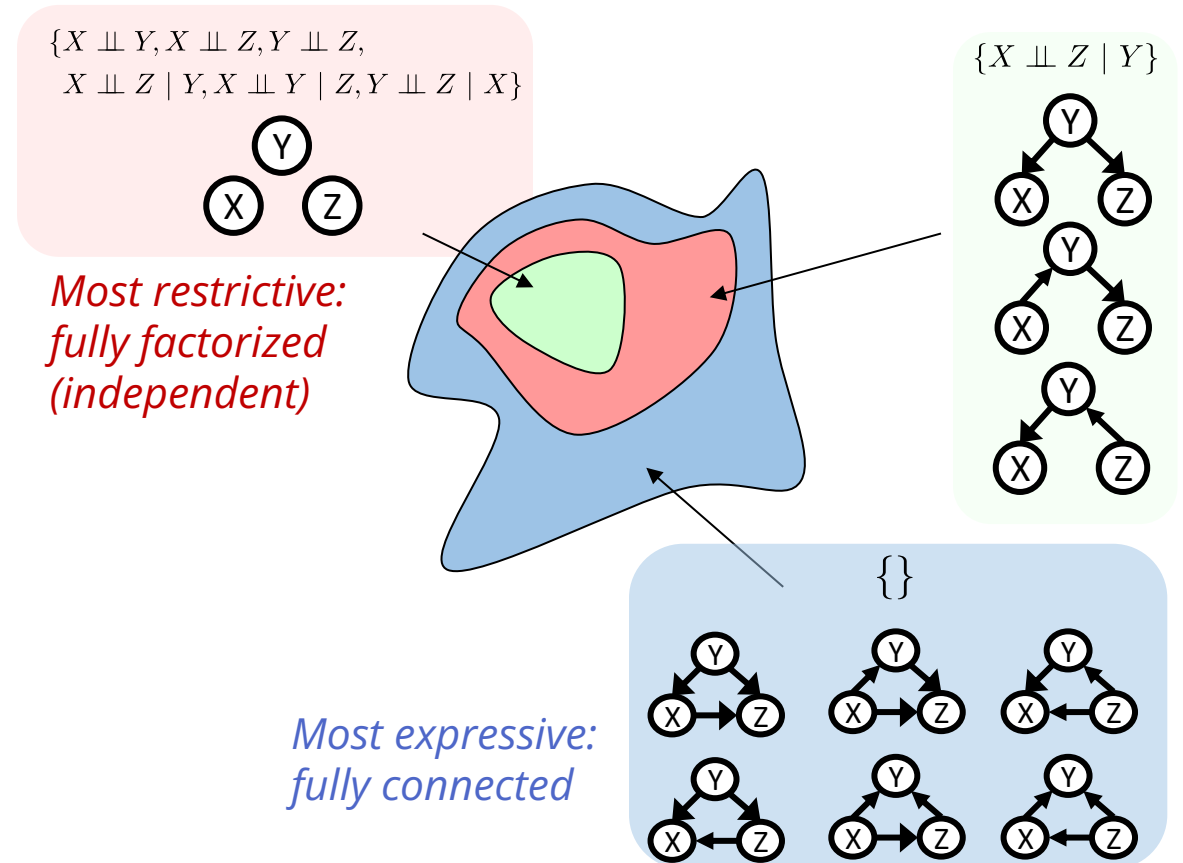


$L \perp B \mid T, R$  ?

*L and B are d-separated given T, R*

# Topology limits distributions

- Given some graph topology  $G$ , only certain joint distributions can be encoded – *only those that satisfy (conditional) independences guaranteed by the graph.*
- Adding edges increases the set of possible distributions: *any independence not assumed by graph can be enforced by parameters.*
- However, adding edges increases the number of parameters and inference complexity



# Summary

- Bayesian networks defined by structure (graph) and parameters (CPTs)
- Bayesian networks compactly represent joint distributions
- BN graph structure (topology) guarantees certain independencies of distributions
- D-separation gives precise conditional independence guarantees from graph alone
- BN joint distribution may still have further (conditional) independences that is not detectable until you inspect its specific distribution (including CPTs)
- Next: probabilistic inference algorithms on BNs
- Reading: [R&N Ch.13](#)